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Video grab of the incident showing activist Vidyanand Bapat (L) being assaulted by Santosh Chavan in full public view on Tilak Road

Anti-DJ activist assaulted on camera

Noise row CROSSES LIMITS

CM Fadnavis, MP Supriya Sule, Pune police chief condemn attack, say freedom of speech is for all; attacker detained

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Pune is once again divided over the deafening roar of DJs and high-powered sound systems that have become synonymous with the city's festivals. On one side are devotees and ordinary citizens who back the traditional Dhol-Tasha during Ganeshotsav but oppose ear-splitting sound. On the other is a camp that defends the use of sound systems, provided they stay within prescribed noise limits.

That simmering tension turned violent on Thursday, when 37-year-old activist Vidyanand Bapat was assaulted in full public view on Tilak Road. He was speaking to the media about the ongoing DJ controversy. The accused, Santosh Chavan, allegedly walked up to Bapat mid-interview and attacked him. Bystanders rushed in to restrain him, and the entire episode was captured on camera.

Chavan was detained by the Vishrambaug police soon after the incident and is currently being interrogated. "The person is detained, and interrogation is ongoing," said Navnath Jagtap, Police Inspector at Vishrambaug police station, on Thursday evening.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 4 »

> Everyone has the right to express their opinion, and attacking someone while they are doing so is unacceptable. We should restore our Ganesh festival to its traditional form and take the necessary steps to achieve that.
> — CM Devendra Fadnavis





> Freedom of speech is for all, and no one is allowed to use such violence. We have detained the person who assaulted Bapat and are interrogating him. Strict action will be taken against the person.
> —Amitesh Kumar,
> Pune Police Commissioner

Sensex loses 417 points, Nifty ends at 23,873 as crude oil price surges
—Equity markets closed lower on Thursday, with Sensex losing 417 points and Nifty 50 declining 41 points amids surging crude oil prices and elevated global yields. The BSE Sensex closed at 76,152.86, down 0.55 per cent, while the Nifty 50 ended at 23,873.45, lower by 0.17 per cent.

Civic neglect continues

Half-done repairs and a blame game leave Swargate depot's internal road riddled with craters

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Commuters face a harrowing time due to the poor condition of raods at the Swargate bus depot

For years, the internal road at Swargate Bus Depot has been a daily ordeal for passengers, commuters and bus staff. Pock-marked by large craters, broken surfaces and uneven stretches, the road has deteriorated into a hazardous and uncomfortable passage, raising questions over the upkeep of a key public transport facility.

The issue gained attention after Pune Times Mirror reported the deplorable condition of the depot's internal road on Thursday, August 20, 2026. Following the report, civic officials deputed a contractor to take up concrete repairs and restore the damaged stretch.

However, the relief proved short-lived. The contractor completed only a small portion of the work before abandoning the site, leaving several craters untouched and the resurfacing incomplete.

Depot officials allege that the contractor was not paid the advance required to begin and complete the work, resulting in the repairs coming to a halt.

Autorickshaw driver Laxman Mali told Pune Times Mirror that the condition of the road has made commuting through the depot a struggle. "There are just potholes and craters instead of a proper road," he said, highlighting how the damaged surface affects motorists and passengers alike.

Mali added that most repairs carried out so far are little more than temporary patchwork. With buses and other heavy vehicles constantly moving through the depot, these patches quickly loosen and deteriorate, sending the road back into its already damaged state.

Work temporarily halted: Depot official

Responding to the concerns raised by Pune Times Mirror over the poor condition of the internal roads at Swargate Bus Depot, Deputy Manager Pramod Gaitonde clarified that the contractor has neither abandoned the project nor stopped the work indefinitely.

Gaitonde said the repair work was temporarily halted due to the heavy movement of traffic during Raksha Bandhan, when the depot witnessed a significant increase in the number of buses and commuters. Continuing the work amid such heavy traffic, he said, would have caused further inconvenience and made it difficult for the contractor to carry out the repairs safely and effectively. The work is expected to resume within a fortnight, he added.

Addressing concerns over the durability of earlier repairs, Gaitonde said that conventional concreting and asphalting tend to deteriorate during the monsoon, with rainwater affecting the surface and reducing the lifespan of the repairs. As an alternative, the authorities now plan to use brickwork to fill and strengthen the damaged craters.


FLASHBACK

City

Driving potholes out

Road repairs in top gear at Swargate bus stop

MIRROR REFLECTS

Kaziranga at a crossroads

'Religion Act invoked prematurely'

Mirror highlighted the issue on August 20, 2026

Non-payment halted work?

An official, speaking on condition of anonymity, told Pune Times Mirror that the contractor had raised concerns over non-payment for the road repair work. According to the official, the contractor stopped work after expressing dissatisfaction over the pending payment and subsequently left the site.

The official claimed that despite the work remaining incomplete, the contractor did not return to resume the repairs, leaving several portions of the depot road riddled with potholes and craters.

While depot authorities maintain that the work has only been temporarily halted and is expected to resume, another official claims that payment-related concerns were the reason the contractor left the site.

Responsibility of PWD or depot, says PMC

Responding to a query from Pune Times Mirror, Dinkar Gojare, Executive Engineer, PMC Road Department, said that the internal road at Swargate Bus Depot does not fall under the Pune Municipal Corporation's jurisdiction.

Gojare said the responsibility for maintaining and repairing the depot's internal road lies either with the Public Works Department (PWD) or the Swargate Bus Depot authorities under the state government.

Depot responsible, says PWD

Responding to a query from Pune Times Mirror, PWD Deputy Engineer Rahul Kadam clarified that the responsibility for repairing the internal road at Swargate Bus Depot lies with the depot authorities and not the Public Works Department (PWD).

Kadam's statement further highlights the confusion over responsibility for the badly damaged road, with different departments pointing towards the depot as the agency responsible for carrying out the repairs. Meanwhile, the road continues to be used daily by buses, auto-rickshaws, passengers and other commuters. However, until someone takes ownership of the problem, the craters continue to belong to everyone who travels through them.

PHOTOS: SWAPNIL JAWALE







'MANACHE' PREPARATIONS
Preparations are underway for the upcoming Ganesh festival at Panchaleshwar Ghat in the Deccan area. The space will witness the grand immersion of Pune's Manache Ganpati. The site, associated with Bappa's farewell, is readied every year to welcome the crowds amidst rituals and emotions on the riverfront.

EDITORIAL

MIRROR REFLECTS

Write to him at feedback@punemirror.com

Is 'Samruddhi' a highway of robbers?

Recents incidents of robberies raise burning question

The Hindu Hriday Samrat Balasaheb Thackeray Samruddhi Mahamarg, built at a cost of thousands of crores, is today paraded as a symbol of Maharashtra's progress. Yet the horrific incidents unfolding daily on this route raise a chilling question: is this truly a highway of prosperity, or become a trap that gambles with travellers' lives and hands robbers a free hunting ground?

Last week's incident in the Sinnar-Vaijapur stretch of the expressway was one that shames humanity and mocks law and order. Under cover of night, sharp iron nails and strips were scattered on the road to puncture the tyres of moving vehicles. The moment the vehicles stopped, a gang of 10 to 12 robbers, who had been lying in wait in the bushes, pounced on the passengers. These brutal criminals did not stop at assault and robbery — they went so far as to snatch a mere 14-month-old infant from its parents' arms, fling the child aside, and hold it hostage while demanding gold and cash. Where does such cruelty, showing no mercy even to an innocent child, come from? The incident makes one thing clear: criminals no longer feel even the slightest fear of the police administration.

On this hi-tech, thousand-crore expressway, tall claims are made about CCTV cameras, patrolling vehicles, and cutting-edge technology. Yet near Sinnar, the robbers' rampage continued unchecked for a full 90 minutes at midnight, with vehicle after vehicle being looted — where, exactly, was the highway police force sleeping? Why do the police wake up only after panicked passengers call for help? Has their duty been reduced to merely showing up to file a report after an accident or a robbery has already happened? Officials boast that patrol teams are stationed every 25 to 30 kilometres — so why does this entire system vanish into thin air the moment there is an actual crisis?

The fundamental question is this: why has the government failed to put in place a security system so airtight that no one would even dare attempt such a robbery? Toll plazas were hastily erected to fill contractors' pockets, and crores of rupees are collected in tolls every single day — yet no corresponding guarantee of passenger safety is offered in return. The government keeps repeating the same tired promises: "we'll install CCTV," "we'll increase patrols," "we'll block traffic and investigate".

Meanwhile, the security fencing running along both sides of the highway lies broken in many places, giving robbers an easy entry point to strike and then vanish into the forest. Why are the MSRDC and the police administration turning a blind eye to these basic lapses? If a traveller has to fire shots in the air to protect himself while driving on this highway, that is not a triumph for the police, it is a symptom of the state's law-and-order machinery going bankrupt.

The government must station high-speed mobile patrols round the clock every 5 to 10 kilometres along the Samruddhi Highway. Broken security fencing must be repaired immediately, and the bushes lining the highway must be cleared. A system must be put in place that guarantees a response to travellers within one to two minutes during emergencies.

If the government and police administration are collecting tolls from the public, then guaranteeing 100 percent safety is their responsibility. These robbers must be taught such a lesson that no one dares look at Samruddhi with evil intent again. If travelling on this highway itself becomes an experience lived in terror, then the government must urgently answer, through action and not words, whether this so-called 'Samruddhi' should instead be called the 'Highway of Robbers'.

— SANDIP PAWAR

CALL TO AMEND JUVENILE LAW

Porsche crash victim's parents say it's needed in serious offences; profusely thank media, police for support

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Om Awadhiya and Savita, parents of Anish who lost his life in the accident involving a Porsche car over two years ago, speak to reporters in Pune on Thursday. (Left) The Porsche that was involved in the accident in May 2024

The parents of Anish Awadhiya, one of the two young victims of the Pune Porsche crash case, on Thursday expressed gratitude to Pune citizens, the media and Pune Police while demanding that the juvenile age be lowered to 16 in serious offences.

"The Central and Maharashtra governments should reconsider existing provisions of the Juvenile Justice Act in cases involving serious and heinous offences committed by minors," Anish's father Om told reporters here.

The young victim's mother, Savita, said the period following the deaths of their son and his colleague Ashwini Koshta have been extremely painful for the families. "The support and sensitivity shown by Puneites gave them strength during the difficult period."

"Some parents don't think twice before giving expensive cars to underage children. The children seem to think that their parents will get them out if they crash the car or get into trouble. There is little fear of the law," said Om.

The parents thanked the journalists and media organisations for highlighting their concerns and bringing the facts of the case before the public. "The media played a significant role in conveying our position and keeping the issue in the public domain," they said.

While expressing their appreciation for the efforts of the police, the parents said they expected the investigation to continue in a fair, transparent and lawful manner.

The major focus of the parents' is on changes in the legal framework governing serious offences involving minors. "The existing provisions could result in individuals being treated differently during legal proceedings because of their age," they said.

According to the parents, there should be safeguards to ensure that provisions meant to protect minors are not misused in cases involving grave offences.

They specifically demanded that when a person aged 16 years or above is accused of a serious or heinous offence, the government should consider a stricter legal process after examining factors such as the gravity of the offence, circumstances of the case and the mental maturity of the accused.

The parents clarified that their demand was not aimed at causing injustice to innocent minors. Instead, they argued that age-related provisions should not become a shield for those accused of committing serious crimes.

The accident

On May 19, 2024, two IT engineers, Ashwini Kosta and Anish Awadhiya from Madhya Pradesh were killed when their motorcycle was hit by a speeding Porsche in Pune's upscale Kalyani Nagar area. Police registered the case against the 17-year-old in conflict with law.

According to the police, the Porsche car was allegedly driven by the minor under the influence of alcohol. Following the accident, investigators alleged that the juvenile's father, a businessman, orchestrated a plan to tamper with evidence.

Businessman targeted

Pays ₹4.24L to cyber crooks for 'ice-cream outlet'

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A 33-year-old man was allegedly duped of Rs 4.24 lakh after cyber fraudsters promised him a franchise of Natural Ice Cream, police said.

The accused allegedly gained his confidence over phone calls and subsequently collected money from him in multiple instalments under the pretext of processing fees.

The incident came to light after the victim realised that the promised franchise was never provided despite making the payments. A case was registered at Parvati Police Station on September 2 against an unidentified person, an email user and the holders of beneficiary bank accounts allegedly linked to the fraud.

According to the complaint filed by Sanket Mansukhlal Shah, a resident of Mitramandal Society in Parvati, he received calls from a person identifying himself as Abhishek Sharma from mobile number 8981883165 between April 13 and 19, 2025.

The caller introduced him to a Natural Ice Cream franchise opportunity and convinced him to proceed with the application.

After gaining Shah's trust, the accused allegedly asked him to make payments towards different charges connected with the franchise process. Believing the representations to be genuine, Shah transferred a total of Rs. 4,24,900 online in several transactions.

However, even after receiving the money, the accused allegedly failed to provide the franchise or complete the promised process. When Shah realised that the offer was fraudulent, he approached the Parvati police and lodged a complaint.

The FIR names the unidentified caller using the name Abhishek Sharma, the user of the email ID info@naturalicreamsfranchises.in, and the

beneficiary of a Central Bank of India account allegedly used for receiving the money. Police are verifying the ownership and use of the mobile number, email account and bank account as part of the investigation.

Beware of lucrative business offers online

Police Inspector Anita Hiravakar said citizens should exercise caution before making payments for franchise or dealership offers received through unknown callers.

"People should independently verify the authenticity of franchise, dealership or business opportunities directly with the concerned company before transferring any money. Fraudsters often use attractive business proposals to gain the confidence of victims and then demand payments under different pretexts. Further investigation is underway." Hiravakar said.

Police are examining the financial transactions and other available details to trace the people involved in the alleged fraud.

Flyover tender scrapped

Chandni Chowk-Bhugaon bridge project cost was inflated by ₹45 cr: Corporator

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The Pune Municipal Corporation (PMC) has cancelled the tender floated for the construction of a 60-metre-wide road from Chandni Chowk to Bhugaon, along with a flyover and a grade separator, following allegations of irregularities in the bidding process. Municipal Commissioner Naval Kishore Ram on Wednesday ordered that the tender be scrapped and a fresh tender floated.

Congress corporator Arvind Shinde had two days ago alleged that the tender conditions were changed to ensure the work went to a contractor favoured by certain quarters. At a press conference, Shinde had alleged irregularities in the process and demanded that the entire tender be cancelled.

"A flyover is proposed on the road from Bhugaon towards Chandni Chowk. There were already suspicions that office-bearers of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party in the civic body were trying to ensure that the work was awarded to a particular contractor. I had also submitted a letter to Municipal Commissioner Ram regarding this," Shinde had said.

He had further alleged a major discrepancy between the estimate prepared by the civic body's estimates committee and the amount quoted in the tender. According to Shinde, the tender had provided for an expenditure Rs 45 crore higher than the estimate prepared by the committee.

> "A flyover is proposed on the road from Bhugaon towards Chandni Chowk. There were already suspicions that office-bearers of the ruling BJP in the civic body were trying to ensure that the work was awarded to a particular contractor.
>
> — Arvind Shinde, Congress corporator

However, the civic administration has disputed the Rs 45-crore increase. Dinkar Gojare, head of the PMC's project department, said the actual difference between the estimated project cost and the amount specified in the tender was only around Rs 1.5 crore.

Gojare said the estimates committee had prepared its estimate in December 2025. Since then, the prices of some materials had increased. Further, changes were required over time between the approved design and the actual work while carrying out the tender process. These factors resulted in an increase of around Rs 1.5 crore over the rate determined by the civic body, he explained.

Re-tendering process soon

Since objections had been raised over the tender process, Commissioner Naval Kishore Ram ordered its cancellation and directed the project department to float a fresh tender. Gojare said the re-tendering process would be initiated in the next few days.

The deadline for submitting bids for the project had been August 26. Shinde had also objected to the extension granted to the bidders after the original deadline.

PUBLIC NOTICE

That, I am concerned for our client Mr. Vinod Satish Rajpurohit is an authorised partner of the firm namely Shivam Developers having its registered office address at1st Floor, 883, Budhwar Peth, Mafatlal Rawal Chambers, Pune - 411002. That, our client Shivam Developers had purchased the said property situated at – Survey No. 61, hissa No. 5b/1/6, Survey No. 61 Hissa No. 5b/1/2/1b, survey No. 61 Hissa No. 5b/1/3/1 within the local limits of the Pune Municipal Corporation and within the jurisdiction of the sub registrar, haveli Pune vide Sale Deed No. 7455/2013 registered at Joint Sub-registrar Class II, Haveli No. 23, Pune from a person namely Mr. Dhanraj Malchand Rathi.

It has come to my Client's attention through the people of neighbourhood that, a lady namely Mrs. Divya Pravin Oswal is attempting to proceed the sales of the said property thereby attempting to create a third-party interest coupled with the acts of trespassing the said property, thereby attempting to use the said property as per her own leisure for partying and other illegal activities, without my knowledge, consent or permission of or without the knowledge, consent or permission of any of the partners or authorised signatories of Shivam Developers. It is to be noted that, the lady namely Mrs. Divya Pravin Oswal has no authorised legal right over the said property.

The same is nothing short of illegal activity and through this public notice it is made aware to the public at large and to the lady named Divya Pravin Oswal that, our client has initiated appropriate criminal and civil proceedings against the lady namely Mrs. Divya Pravin Oswal. It is further made aware to the public at large that Any transaction, document, sale, loan, lien or mortgages, lease or licences etc that exists or is proposed to be availed that is arising out of the said property as represented by Mrs. Divya Pravin Oswal, my client has reserved the right to prosecute all the people actively or non-actively involved in creating any other right. My client intends to move civil suit on the said property and this notice is issued in public interest in order to refrain any third party interests.

ADV. RUPALI PATIL THOMBARE

पुणे महानगरपालिका

विषय : पुणे महानगरपालिका वैद्यकीय शिक्षण ट्रस्टचे भारतरत्न अटलबिहारी वाजपेयी वैद्यकीय महाविद्यालयामध्ये नियमित शिक्षक पदभरती करणेसाठी सहाय्यक प्राध्यापक, सहयोगी प्राध्यापक व प्राध्यापक पदांच्या मुलाखती घेणेसाठी मुलाखत वेळापत्रक प्रसिद्ध करणेबाबत.

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जाहिरात क्र. १/७०६ दि. ०३/०९/२०२६

Noise row crosses limits

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Condemning the attack, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis expressed regret over the incident, saying differences of opinion should never turn violent. "It is not right to assault someone in this manner. Everyone has the right to express their opinion, and attacking someone while they are doing so is unacceptable."

"The police have arrested the accused in this case. We should try to understand one another. Such disputes are inappropriate in a city like Pune. We should restore our Ganesh festival to its traditional form and take the necessary steps to achieve that," Fadnavis added.

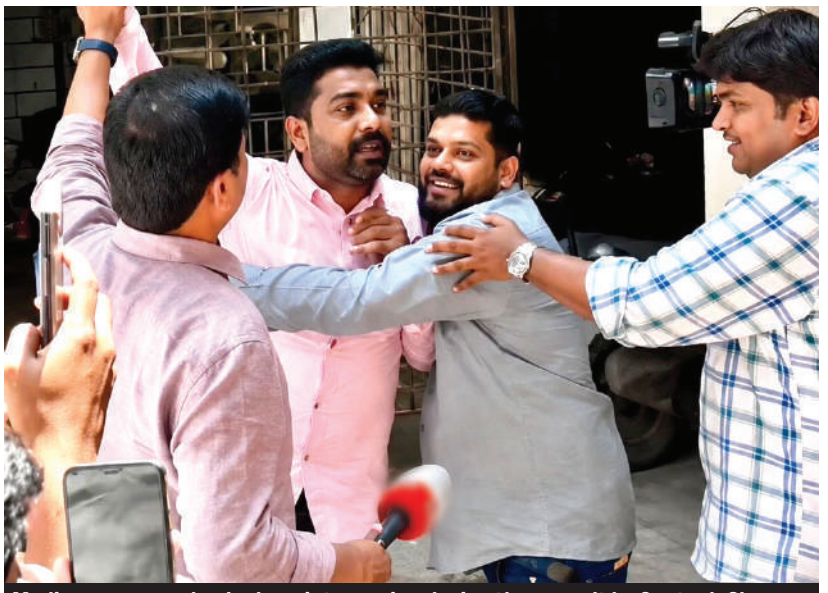
Pune Police Commissioner Amitesh Kumar echoed the sentiment and promised strict action. "We have detained the person who assaulted Bapat. We are also interrogating him and taking his statement; strict action will be taken against the person."

Kumar added, "Freedom of speech is for all, and no one is allowed to use such violence. We do not yet know the reason why the person took such action; we officers were in a meeting, and I will gather details from the people who interrogated him. Action will be taken as per law."

'A madman suddenly appeared'

Bapat, who has been vocal about the need to keep Ganesh festival celebrations from inconveniencing the general public, said he had no warning of the attack. "A madman suddenly appeared and attacked me. You witnessed it. Why did he attack me? He attacked after seeing that I was unarmed, or perhaps after noticing that there were no police officers nearby. He merely wanted cheap publicity and instant fame. You saw everything, so you already know what happened," he said.

Police have said the exact motive for the assault is yet to be established, and further action will depend on what emerges from Chavan's interrogation.



Mediapersons and onlookers intervening during the assault by Santosh Chavan

OPPOSITION CONDEMNS ASSAULT

The incident has also drawn a sharp political response. Supriya Sule, NCP MP, wrote on X: "I had a conversation with Vidyanand Bapat, who has taken a firm stand against DJ. The incident is utterly condemnable. In a democratic system, everyone has the right to express their opinion. Even if we do not agree with someone's view, that view and the right to express it must be respected."

"However, in recent times, the tendency to suppress the voices of those expressing opposing views through beatings and thuggery to silence them is extremely harmful to democracy. Responding to ideological differences with violence is a method that in no way befits Maharashtra's cultured and progressive traditions. We strongly condemn the assault on Bapat."

"Ganeshotsav is an inseparable part of Maharashtra's rich cultural heritage. It should be celebrated with great enthusiasm and joy, staying in harmony with changing times while preserving the essence of our culture. Ordinary citizens expect Ganeshotsav to unite society, bring joy, and boost enthusiasm," Sule wrote.

Two men, two very different backgrounds

Chavan, who attacked Bapat, is a resident of Rautwadi in Kothrud, and reportedly works for a property developer. He is the founding president of the Janjagruti Pratishthan Mandal in the area. By his own account, he is a devotee of Lord Ganesha, but he has offered no explanation for attacking Bapat, leaving the motive behind the assault still unclear.

Bapat, by contrast, has no prominent political or social background. Originally from Ratnagiri, he has lived in Pune's Narayan Peth for the past eight years, works in the BPO sector largely from home, and holds a Bachelor of Commerce degree from the University of Mumbai. He is also known to participate in initiatives run by progressive groups in the city.

FIR sought against Bapat

In a twist to the controversy, a group of activists has approached the Deccan Gymkhana police station with applications demanding that an FIR be registered against Bapat himself. They contend that Bapat is not merely opposing DJs and sound systems but is disrespecting Pune's traditional Ganesh festival and using the media to spread hatred against it.

Police Commissioner Amitesh Kumar confirmed the development. "We have received the application and are reviewing it," he said.

Don't treat DJ as your enemy: Chavan's viral post

Even as the police probe the assault, a social media post attributed to Chavan has gone viral. It stated that he completely opposed the ideologies of Bapat. "If every DJ follows sound permissible limits, then it does not cause any health hazard. All the Ganesh mandals are ready to follow the guidelines given by Pune police; why is Bapat making it such a big issue?"

Chavan further added in his post: "Bapat saheb, we respect your thoughts but don't consider the DJ as your enemy and don't ban it completely, as that is not the solution."

GOVT. OF MAHARASHTRA

Public Works Division, Pune - 411 001
Phone No. 020/26122485 & 26122414 Fax No. 020/26122485
Web- www.mahapwd.gov.in & e-mail- pune.ee@mahapwd.gov.in

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. 34 FOR 2026-2027

The Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Pune 411 001 invites bids **for above Rs. 100.00 Lakhs Estimated Cost Works** from Registered as well as unregistered Contractor who full filling the qualifying criteria in **B-2 Tender Format** as per G.R. No. Maharashtra Government, Public Work Department G.R. No. CAT/2017/Pra. Kra-08/Bldg-2, dt. 27/9/2018 and G.R. No. CAT/2017/Pra. Kra-08/Bldg-2, dt. 22/10/2018 and G.R. No. CAT/2017/Pra. Kra-8/Bldg-2 dt. 20/5/2021 and G.R. No. CAT/2017/Pra. Kra-08/Bldg-2 dt. 21/08/2023 and G.R. No. Misc-2022/Pra Kra. 104/Bldg-2 dt. 14/2/2025.

Bids document can be downloaded from website **https://mahatenders.gov.in** Executive Engineer reserves all rights to accept or reject bids. Conditional bids will not be accepted.

Period of Sale of online Tender Document and Submission of Tender	:-	Dt. 04/09/2026 @ 10.00 hrs. to Dt. 21/09/2026 @ 18.00 hrs.
Pre-bid Meeting	:-	Dt. 11/09/2026 @ 12.00 hrs. In the Office of The Chief Engineer, P. W. Region, Pune, New Central Building, Pune -1.
Period of online Tender opening	:-	Dt. 24/09/2026 @ 10.00 hrs. (If Possible)

The detailed Tender Notice can be is available on

1. Web- www.mahapwd.gov.in (Only Tender Notice)
2. https://mahatenders.gov.in
   (Any changes in the NIT will be Corrigendum's published on above website)
3. Notice Board @ o/o Executive Engineer, P. W. Division, Pune, Central Building, Pune -1.

Sd/-
(Prashant S. Khairmode)
Executive Engineer,
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EMPOWERING SINGLE WOMEN

First-ever state-level survey begins for rehabilitation, support to those living in urban areas

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AI GENERATED IMAGE

Maharashtra has, for the first time, started a statewide survey of single women living in urban, paving the way for their official registration with the government and the creation of a database to help empower and rehabilitate them.

The initiative has its roots in the COVID-19 pandemic, when many women lost the male breadwinners. Recognising the need to help such women become self-reliant and access government welfare schemes, the Saau Single Women Committee, led by Heramb Kulkarni of Akole, began pursuing the issue with the government.

Following the committee's efforts, a survey of such women was undertaken across Maharashtra. The committee subsequently began pressing for a wider survey covering single women from all backgrounds.

State convenor Kulkarni, coordinator Milindkumar Salve and their colleagues pursued the matter at various levels.

As a pilot initiative, the Ahmednagar Zilla Parishad conducted a survey that identified around 1.5 lakh single women in the district. Under the guidance of Guardian and Water Resources Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, a district-level Single Women Empowerment Committee was constituted during the bicentenary year of the birth anniversary of Rajmata Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar.

A range of measures for their welfare and empowerment were subsequently initiated under the leadership of District Collector Pankaj Ashiya and Zilla Parishad Chief Executive Officer Anand Bhandari.

The issue then moved to the state level. A meeting was held at the Maharashtra Legislature in the chamber of the then Deputy Chairperson of the Legislative Council, Dr Neelam Gorhe, with Saau Committee representatives Kulkarni and Salve, the then Women and Child Development Commissioner Nayana Gunde and former commissioner and Resident Commissioner of Maharashtra Sadan in Delhi, R Vimala, among others.

As the next step, V Radha, Additional Chief Secretary of the General Administration Department and Guardian Secretary of Pune district, took the initiative to conduct a pilot project in Pune for the empowerment and rehabilitation of single women. Following this, Pune Zilla Parishad CEO Gajanan Patil undertook a survey of single women in the district's rural areas and worked with various departments to formulate programmes for their empowerment.

The survey in rural Pune was subsequently completed. V Radha and Patil also presented the measures being undertaken for the empowerment of single women in Pune to the late Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar at the Pune District Collectorate and at Mantralaya.

Pawar, Minister Vikhe Patil, Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare and Gorhe took up the issue following the sustained efforts of the Saau Committee.

> **"The Directorate has issued orders to register single women living in urban areas across the state. We are following up on the implementation of these orders. The survey will help us in their rehabilitation. We are making efforts to complete the exercise as soon as possible.**
>
> **— Sheela Patil,** Deputy Commissioner, Directorate of Municipal Administration, Mumbai

> **"The data on single women will be used for their empowerment and for formulating various welfare schemes. Keeping this in mind, the maximum number of eligible women must be registered.**
>
> **— Milindkumar Salve,** State Coordinator, Saau Single Women Committee

The matter of empowering single women subsequently gained prominence. While presenting the state budget, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis announced that Maharashtra would formulate the country's first dedicated policy for single women. A drafting committee has since been constituted and work on it started.

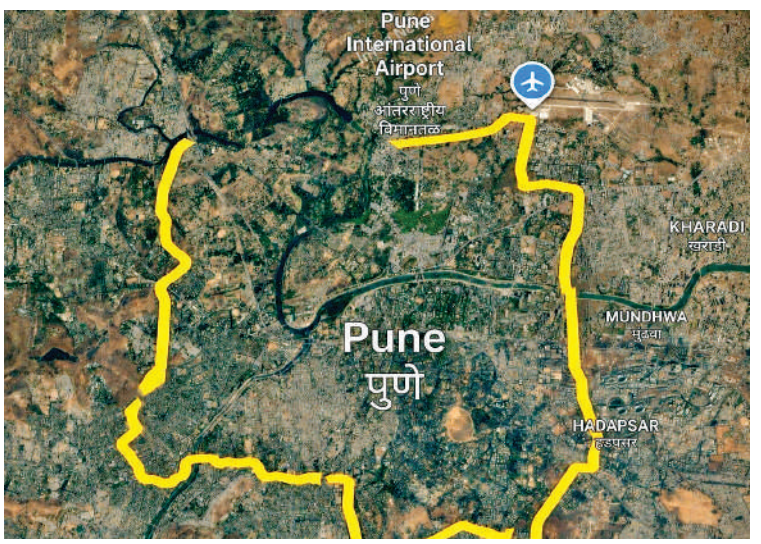
Accordingly, Deputy Commissioner of the Directorate of Municipal Administration, Sheela Patil, has now directed the commissioners and chief officers of all municipal corporations, municipalities and nagar panchayats in the state to conduct door-to-door surveys of single women within their respective jurisdictions.

4 firms in race for HCMTR project

PMC opens technical bids for consultancy before constn tender

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The Pune Municipal Corporation's ambitious High Capacity Mass Transit Route (HCMTR) project has taken another step forward, with four engineering consultancy firms submitting bids for the technical work required before the construction tender. The technical bids for appointing a consultant were opened on September 1.

The firms in the fray are Shrikhande Consultants Ltd, Stup Consultants Pvt Ltd, Technogem Consultants Pvt Ltd and TPF Engineering Pvt Ltd. Their technical capabilities and experience will now be evaluated before the financial bids for eligible ones are opened and final consultant is appointed. The consultancy assignment is expected to run for 90 days.

As per the original plan, the HCMTR is a 35.96-km, six-lane, fully elevated circular route proposed to ease traffic congestion across Pune. The route is largely planned on single pillars, with a proposed right-of-way of 24 metres. Starting from Bopodi Junction, it will skirt the city before reaching Vishrantwadi.

As per the original plan, the HCMTR is a 35.96-km, six-lane, fully elevated circular route proposed to ease traffic congestion across Pune. The route is largely planned on single pillars, with a proposed right-of-way of 24 metres. Starting from Bopodi Junction, it will skirt the city before reaching Vishrantwadi

The project is expected to ease traffic pressure at 34 major junctions, with entry and exit ramps proposed at 17 locations. The main carriageway has been designed for a speed of 50 kmph, while the ramps will have a design speed of 25 kmph.

Of the original 35.96-km alignment, around 17.8 km is proposed along existing roads, while 5.28 km will pass through areas involving drains, canals and the river. Another 5.34 km is proposed through forest land, open spaces, green areas and railway land. The remaining 7.54 km will pass through built-up areas, slums and vacant plots.

The alignment has been modified at 12 locations to reduce land acquisition costs and avoid potential conflicts with existing and proposed Metro routes.

Meanwhile, the revised proposal is expected to increase the length of the complete circular route to around 43 km, following the addition of the incomplete Vishrantwadi-Bopodi link.

The consultant appointed by the PMC will be responsible for updating earlier technical reports, conducting environmental impact studies, verifying land records and preparing the documents required for the construction tender.

The civic administration has made a preliminary provision of Rs 3,000 crore for the project and has set a target of floating the construction tender in October. Once completed, the HCMTR is expected to provide buses, private vehicles and emergency services with a faster and uninterrupted alternative route across the city.

> **"Preparations for the HCMTR project are under way on a war footing. Once the Detailed Project Report is ready, we will float the tender within three months.**
>
> **— Naval Kishore Ram,** Commissioner, PMC

100 YEARS OF TRADITION, FAITH AND SERVICE



Ranmard Shivaji Mandal's centenary celebrations blend tradition, community service and grand Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj coronation tableau

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Ranmard Shivaji Mandal, one of Pune's oldest and most respected Ganeshotsav mandals, is celebrating its centenary this year. The mandal, located at Nehru Chowk in Shukrawar Peth, will mark the milestone with a mix of traditional religious celebrations and its regular social initiatives.

As part of the much-discussed Pune Ganesh Festival, centenary-old Ganeshotsav mandals from across the city will be felicitated by Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan. Ranmard Shivaji Mandal, which was established in 1926, is among the mandals being honoured this year.

The mandal is known for celebrating Ganeshotsav in a traditional yet grand manner. Its 100th festival will continue that tradition, while also carrying forward the social activities undertaken by its members every year. The centenary is therefore being viewed not merely as a celebration of longevity, but also as an opportunity to reaffirm the mandal's longstanding connection with the community.

Nehru Chowk, situated on the route from the old market towards Bohri Ali, has been a prominent landmark for generations. For several years, Ranmard Shivaji Mandal has erected its Ganeshotsav pavilion at the junction in a manner that allows traffic to continue below it. Despite the area remaining crowded with shops and visitors, particularly during the festive season, the mandal's volunteers take care to ensure that their arrangements do not add to traffic congestion.

At the beginning of Ganeshotsav, the mandal traditionally organises a Vasapuja ceremony with great enthusiasm. The event is attended by Ganesh devotees and prominent citizens from across Pune. This year, the Vasapuja was performed by entrepreneur Punit Balan.

Aid to orphanages

The mandal's activities extend beyond the festival. Every year, on the occasion of Ganesh Yagna, its volunteers distribute clothes and foodgrains at an orphanage in Saswad, provide essential items to orphaned children at Sassoon Hospital and extend assistance to old-age homes. Kojagiri Purnima is also celebrated with a procession dedicated to the goddess, followed by distribution of milk. Various national festivals are celebrated with equal enthusiasm.

These initiatives form an important part of the mandal's identity and reflect its emphasis on community service alongside religious celebrations. Members have continued these activities as a regular responsibility, ensuring that the festival also becomes an occasion to reach out to those in need.

Special attraction

The centenary celebrations will have a special attraction this year — a grand tableau depicting the coronation ceremony of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. Artists from Mumbai and Ahilyanagar are working on the palace set and idols for the presentation. Around 55 large and small idols will form part of the tableau.

A sound-and-light presentation, background music and narration will be used to bring the tableau alive. Renowned sculptors are supervising the entire decorative work, said mandal president Balasaheb Dhamdhere. Kishor Nanaware is the vice-president.

As usual, traditional performances only

The mandal has also consistently promoted traditional dhol-tasha performances during the immersion procession. Dhamdhere said the mandal does not use DJs or loudspeakers that cause disturbance during the procession, choosing instead to maintain the traditional character of the celebrations. The approach reflects the mandal's effort to preserve the cultural and devotional character of Ganeshotsav while marking its historic 100th year.

Celebration of devotion and fragrance

Before Pune's pandals come alive, flower vendors and workers wake up early to keep the city's beloved festival blooming

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Long before the drums begin to echo through Pune's streets and Ganesh pandals start glowing with lights, another side of the festival is already in full swing. As the city sleeps, Pune's flower markets begin to stir, with vendors, workers, and traders preparing for the rush that comes with Ganeshotsav. Before Pune welcomes Ganesha with flowers, these people wake up to bring those flowers to the city.

By the early hours of the morning, baskets and sacks filled with marigold, roses, chrysanthemums, lotus and other flowers begin arriving at the market. Within minutes, the quiet space turns into a colourful, fast-moving workplace. Vendors sort flowers, workers carry heavy loads and garland makers sit patiently stringing hundreds of flowers together.

For many small vendors, Ganeshotsav is more than a religious celebration — it is an important opportunity to earn. The increased demand for flowers during the festival brings more customers and, for some families, a much-needed boost to their seasonal income. Behind every garland sold outside a temple, home or Ganesha pandal is a vendor who may have started work before sunrise.

The festival rush, however, also brings its challenges. Prices can fluctuate with demand and supply, while maintaining fresh stock throughout the day is a constant struggle. Flowers that remain unsold eventually lose their value and can become waste, adding another concern to the celebrations.

Yet, despite the long hours, heavy lifting and unpredictable business, the enthusiasm among the sellers remains visible. For them, the arrival of Ganeshotsav signals weeks of hard work — but also the hope of better earnings.

As devotees across Pune prepare to welcome their beloved Ganesha, thousands of flowers will become part of the celebrations. But behind the fragrance, colour and decoration are the hands of workers and vendors who quietly keep the festival moving.

PHOTOS: SWAPNIL JAWALE







Flower vendors at Market Yard and Mahatma Phule Mandai

"For us, Ganeshotsav is not just a festival; it is also a season of hope. We start work before sunrise and spend the entire day selling flowers. The rush is tiring, but these few weeks can make a big difference to our family's earnings.
— Vedant Pawar, Flower vendor, Market Yard

"People see the beautiful garlands decorating Ganesha idols, but they rarely see the work behind them. By the time the city wakes up, we have made hundreds of garlands.
— Mohan Shelar, Garland maker, Market Yard

"Every year, we come here to buy flowers for Ganesha. The fragrance, the colours and the decoration make the celebrations feel complete.
— Harshal Mahajan Buyer, Market Yard

"We have been selling flowers for generations. Ganeshotsav comes for only a few days, but for us, the festival leaves behind memories — and, hopefully, enough earnings to carry our family through the coming months.
— Tukaram Jadhav Flower vendor, Mandai

Civic body preps for Ganeshotsav

Commissioner directs officials to prioritise roads, cleanliness, electrical safety, and immersion arrangements

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Electrical wires and connections should be checked for safety in view of Ganeshotsav, and action should be taken against dangerous connections in coordination with the concerned agencies. Preparations for artificial immersion tanks, cleanliness, lighting and security arrangements should be completed on time. Every ward officer should effectively discharge the responsibility of keeping their ward clean, attractive and safe for citizens. Footpaths should be cleared for pedestrians, public toilets cleaned regularly, trees pruned and road repairs completed on time. Beat inspectors should closely monitor unauthorised constructions and take immediate action for their removal, Municipal Commissioner Dr Vijay Suryawanshi directed.

Dr Suryawanshi reviewed the functioning of various civic departments at a meeting held at the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation's (PCMC) main administrative building in Pimpri in view of the upcoming Ganeshotsav and various civic amenities in the city. The meeting reviewed encroachments, unauthorised constructions, cleanliness arrangements, the condition of roads and footpaths, electrical safety measures, gardens, preparations for artificial immersion tanks for Ganesh idols and the redressal of citizens' complaints. The Commissioner was speaking while issuing necessary instructions to the concerned officials.

Additional Commissioners Kuldeep Jangam, Vikrant Bagade and Trupti Sandbhor, Joint Commissioner Manoj Lonkar, City Engineer Manoj Sethia, Deputy City Engineers Ajay Suryawanshi and Prerna Sinkar, Medical Officer of Health Dr Laxman Gophane, Deputy Commissioners Sachin Pawar, Sitaram Bahure, Rajesh Agale, Dr Pradeep Thengal, Anna Bodde, Venkatesh Durvas, Sandeep Khot and Pankaj Patil, Chief Garden Superintendent Mahesh Gargote, Assistant Commissioners Amit Pandit and Tanaji Narale, ward officers Atul Patil, Ashwini Gaikwad, Nivedita Gharage, Ajinkya Yele, Pooja Dudhnale, Parshuram Waghmode and Gorakshanath Limhan, Chief Security Officer Uday Jarande and Special Officer Kiran Gaikwad, along with executive engineers and staff from the civil, electrical, environment and other departments, were present.


The meeting was attended by Municipal Commissioner Dr Vijay Suryawanshi and civic officials

Prepare immersion tanks on time

The necessary preparations for artificial immersion tanks across the city should be completed on time for the immersion of Ganesh idols. Cleanliness, lighting, security and essential facilities for citizens should be provided at immersion sites. During Ganeshotsav, various departments should work in coordination to ensure safe and smooth civic services for citizens.

In addition, the safety of electrical wires and connections across the city should be checked in view of Ganeshotsav. Immediate action should be taken against dangerous or unauthorised electrical connections in coordination with the concerned agencies. The city's cleanliness arrangements should also be strengthened during the festival, while work to make roads pothole-free should be completed on a priority basis.

Push for wards free of encroachments

Every ward officer is responsible for keeping their ward clean, attractive and free of encroachments. Encroachments on footpaths within the jurisdiction of ward offices should be removed immediately and the footpaths cleared for pedestrians. Public toilets in the wards should be cleaned regularly, trees pruned from time to time and necessary action taken to keep roads in good condition.

Beat inspectors should closely monitor unauthorised constructions in their respective wards. Information about newly emerging unauthorised constructions should be immediately brought to the notice of the concerned department and action taken for their removal. Care should be taken to ensure that unauthorised constructions are not encouraged under any circumstances, and strict action should be taken against violators as per the rules.

Along with taking effective action against unauthorised constructions in the city, action should be taken as per rules to disconnect water connections and electricity supplies provided to such structures. In addition to demolition or removal action against unauthorised constructions, legal action should also be initiated in the concerned cases.

Department heads should immediately take cognisance of complaints received from citizens through the municipal corporation's Sarathi system and government websites and resolve them within the stipulated time. Officials should regularly review complaints to ensure that none remain pending and maintain records of the action taken.

Rise in swine flu cases

31 recorded in August as healthcare system appears unprepared

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WATCH FOR THESE SYMPTOMS

- High fever and body aches
- Persistent cough and throat irritation
- Difficulty in breathing or chest pain
- Diarrhoea and vomiting

Swine flu (H1N1) is tightening its grip on Pimpri-Chinchwad, with cases rising sharply over the past few days and triggering concern among citizens. Seasonal changes and the ongoing monsoon have led to a rise in infectious diseases across the city, with H1N1 emerging as one of the fastest-spreading infections. Despite the growing number of cases, the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation's (PCMC) medical department is yet to put in place any concrete mechanism to tackle the situation, raising questions over the civic administration's preparedness.

The total number of swine flu cases in the city has now reached 37, of which 31 were reported in August alone. The sudden rise comes at a time when viral infections are spreading rapidly during the monsoon, putting the preparedness of the city's health machinery under scrutiny. Private and government hospitals are witnessing a steady influx of patients suffering from cold, cough and high fever, with several subsequently testing positive for H1N1.

While cases continue to climb, the PCMC's medical department appears to have been slow to respond. Citizens have alleged that basic measures such as creating awareness, promptly testing suspected patients and undertaking preventive spraying in different wards have not been given adequate attention.

Timely intervention must

Given that swine flu is highly contagious, timely intervention is crucial to contain its spread.

The virus spreads through the air and close contact with an infected person. Doctors in private practice have advised citizens to avoid crowded places, use a handkerchief or tissue while coughing or sneezing, and seek medical advice promptly if symptoms develop rather than resorting to self-medication.

Skills centre to come up

Facility in Moshi to provide education, training and opportunities

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A new holistic development centre offering education, values-based learning, skill development and opportunities for self-reliance is set to come up for children from deprived tribal, nomadic and denotified and backward communities. The state government's decision has cleared the way for the establishment of the development centre at Moshi.

The state government has decided to allot 15 hectares, or around 37 acres, of government land at Moshi to the Krantiveer Chapekar Committee-run Krantiteerth Chapekar Brothers National Museum and Punarutthan Samarasata Gurukulam aided tribal residential school.

The proposal was approved at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Devendraji Fadnavis. Accordingly, the Revenue Department headed by Revenue Minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule issued an official Government Resolution on August 31, 2026. A holistic development centre for the backward and deprived tribal communities will be established on the land.

The 15-hectare plot in Gat No. 327 (old Survey No. 325) at Moshi will be allotted to the organisation. The institution will hold the land under the 'Occupant Class-II' category.

"My social work began with the objective of ensuring that, along with education, the traditional knowledge, art and skills of children from tribal, deprived and nomadic and denotified communities are preserved. The availability of 15 hectares at Moshi has created a major opportunity to expand this work. We are committed to establishing a holistic development centre here that will integrate education, values, skills, research and self-reliance," said Padma Shri Girish Prabhune, Founder, Punarutthan Samarasata Gurukulam.

More opportunities for students

The decision is expected to create wider opportunities for students from deprived tribal as well as nomadic and denotified communities in Maharashtra to receive quality education in a safe and nurturing environment. Along with formal education, the centre will seek to preserve traditional knowledge, art and skills while integrating them with modern education and technology.

Through the Krantiveer Chapekar Committee, Krantiteerth Chapekar Brothers National Museum and Punarutthan Samarasata Gurukulam, an integrated centre combining education, residential training, values-based learning, research, traditional knowledge, modern skills and social development will be developed on the proposed site.

Variety of programmes

The centre will enable various educational and skill-based programmes aimed at building confidence, self-respect and self-reliance among students. The project encourages the talents of children from tribal and nomadic and denotified communities and helps them join the mainstream of development.

"15 hectares of land at Moshi have been allotted to Punarutthan Samarasata Gurukulam. This decision will provide strong support to children from deprived tribal and nomadic and denotified communities. Giving the last person in society an opportunity for education, values, skills and self-reliance and bringing about social regeneration is the true objective of this initiative," said Shankar Jagtap, MLA, Chinchwad.

Trash piles up in twin towns

PCMC plans alternative processing sites and hopes to revive waste-to-energy plant in October

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The fatal accident at Moshi has exposed the vulnerabilities in Pimpri-Chinchwad's waste management system, with garbage piling up at several locations across the city and residents having to contend with foul odour. Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Commissioner Dr Vijay Suryawanshi said the administration was aware of the seriousness of the situation and had been working continuously to address the problem. He said a decision on new sites required for waste processing and the Waste-to-Energy project would be taken within the next seven to eight days.

The issue came up for detailed discussion during the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) general body meeting on Wednesday, with corporators questioning the administration over the garbage accumulating across the city, the July 8 accident at Moshi, the Waste-to-Energy project, the number of garbage collection vehicles and the availability of waste processing centres. Responding to the concerns, Suryawanshi said the administration had not ignored the issue and had worked on waste management every day during the past 50 days.


FILE PHOTO

"The waste management problem has become serious because it has depended on a single depot. We are now trying to establish alternative waste processing centres or transfer stations in every zone. In some places, waste from one ward may have to be processed in another ward. This is a 40-year-old problem and cannot be resolved in a few days. Residents of Moshi should cooperate with the administration," said Dr Vijay Suryawanshi.

Garbage has accumulated at several locations in the city following the Moshi accident, creating a serious nuisance for residents. Suryawanshi said the administration was as concerned about the situation as the elected representatives. At a meeting held on July 15, the possibility of establishing a waste processing centre in every ward was discussed. While questions were being raised over what the administration had done during the intervening period, the Commissioner said there had not been a single day in the past 50 days when officials had not worked on the waste management issue.

Sites yet to be finalised

The administration initially did not have a clear picture of the number of reserved plots available for waste processing centres. Officials subsequently discussed the issue with office-bearers and physically inspected the identified sites. The inspections revealed that some of the available plots were large enough only for dry waste processing.

At present, 12 sites have been shortlisted for waste management activities, although none has been finalised. The administration will take a final decision after discussions with corporators from the respective wards. Of these 12 locations, six are proposed to be used exclusively for processing dry waste.

The PCMC has also invited several companies to make presentations on different waste processing technologies. However, setting up such projects will take time as the Detailed Project Report (DPR) has to be prepared, plans approved and supporting infrastructure created. A Bio-CNG project would require at least 10 acres of land.

The administration therefore cannot be expected to resolve the waste problem immediately, Suryawanshi said, pointing out that practical and technical constraints also had to be considered while planning new facilities.

PROCESSING CENTRES IN ALL ZONES PLANNED

The city's waste problem has become particularly acute because waste management has been heavily dependent on a single dumping site. The administration is now working towards establishing alternative waste processing centres or transfer stations in every zone. This could also mean that waste generated in one ward may have to be transported to another ward for processing, depending on the availability of facilities.

> "The waste management problem has become serious because it has depended on a single depot. We are now trying to establish alternative waste processing centres or transfer stations in every zone. In some places, waste from one ward may have to be processed in another ward. This is a 40-year-old problem and cannot be resolved in a few days. Residents of Moshi should cooperate with the administration.
> — **Dr Vijay Suryawanshi,** Commissioner, PCMC

Waste-to-energy plant was shut before tragedy

Clarifying the status of the Waste-to-Energy project, Suryawanshi said the plant had stopped functioning around one and a half months before the Moshi accident. The collapse of the chimney subsequently made the situation more difficult and added to the pressure on the city's waste management system. The chimney is expected to be repaired by the end of September. The PCMC plans to attempt to restart the Waste-to-Energy plant in October. Once operational, the facility is expected to process around 1,000 tonnes of waste a day.

'Jayanti' extravaganza under lens

State orders simplicity; new policy proposed to bring spending under control; annual budget planned

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Despite strict directions from the State Government to celebrate the birth anniversaries of national leaders and other eminent personalities and national days in a simple manner, the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) has been spending crores of rupees every year on such events. A large portion of this expenditure has gone towards Prabodhan Parva programmes and entertainment events organised as part of the celebrations.

The issue has now prompted the civic administration to move towards a comprehensive policy to bring uniformity to the planning of birth and death anniversaries and national celebrations organised by the PCMC, besides ensuring greater transparency in expenditure. The issue was discussed at a meeting of the Standing Committee, following which committee Chairman Abhishek Barne directed officials of the concerned department to prepare a proposal for the policy.

"It is our duty to take the thoughts and work of great personalities to future generations. However, any irregularity or delay in organising their birth anniversaries, national celebrations and various festivals through the PCMC will not be tolerated. The accounts of every programme must be transparent. We are introducing this comprehensive policy to avoid the last-minute rush caused by delays in the tendering process. The standard operating procedure will be strictly implemented from the upcoming celebrations in October and November so that all these events are conducted in a more disciplined, presentable and quality manner," said Barne.

Main objective

The main objective of the proposed policy is to ensure transparency in the expenditure and organisation of birth anniversaries of great personalities, memorial days and national celebrations held throughout the year in Pimpri-Chinchwad. A fixed annual budget and a yearly tendering process for these events have also been proposed.

The PCMC has been spending crores of rupees from its coffers on celebrations of various great personalities. Questions are now being raised over the spending of taxpayers' money on such programmes.

On December 27, 2023, the State Government's General Administration Department issued a circular laying down guidelines and restrictions for celebrating the birth anniversaries of national leaders and other eminent personalities and national days. The circular specifies how the birth anniversaries of 44 personalities should be observed and the nature of programmes to be organised. However, allegations have been made that the PCMC has failed to follow these directions while organising the celebrations.



The ruling political parties have also come under scrutiny over the expenditure. Both the NCP and BJP have faced criticism over the manner in which such celebrations have been organised, with allegations that the Government's guidelines have not been strictly followed.

Strict implementation of the Government's directives could help the PCMC save crores of rupees every year. Taxpayers have expressed displeasure over the civic body's spending on such events while several basic civic issues continue to demand attention.

> "The standard operating procedure will be strictly implemented from the upcoming celebrations in October and November so that all these events are conducted in a more disciplined, presentable and quality manner.
> — **Abhishek Barne,** PCMC Standing Committee Chairman

Public relations dept under scrutiny

The PCMC's public relations department organises these celebrations. However, despite the existence of a Sports, Arts, Literature and Cultural Committee, complaints have been raised that the committee is not kept informed about the programmes. Local corporators and civic office-bearers are also reportedly not given prior information about the events.

To put an end to such practices, Barne directed officials to frame the proposed policy while considering suggestions from the Mayor, Deputy Mayor, Standing Committee chairman, party leaders, all-party group leaders and other office-bearers. He directed that the proposal be prepared and submitted within the next eight days.

Annual planning to end last-minute tenders

Under the proposed policy, the practice of preparing separate documents for every jayanti, issuing tenders at the last minute and bringing proposals before the Standing Committee for approval after delays will be brought to an end.

If all the programmes are planned annually in advance, the quality of the events can be improved while saving administrative time, officials believe. The proposed system will allow the civic body to plan the celebrations in advance instead of going through separate tendering and approval procedures for each event.

Oct-Nov celebrations to be planned first

To implement the new policy at the earliest, the PCMC has decided to start planning immediately for the birth anniversaries and memorial days of prominent personalities falling in October and November.

BREATHING DIFFICULTY? IT COULD BE ALLERGIC RHINITIS

As monsoon humidity fuels mould and dust mites, doctors report a 15% rise in cases and warn against mistaking it for a common cold



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As intermittent rain and high humidity continue to grip Pune, doctors across the city are noticing a sharp uptick in allergic rhinitis cases. Respiratory specialists estimate a 15 percent rise in the condition this monsoon, with damp weather, mould growth and a surge in dust mites emerging as the chief culprits. Closed windows and poor indoor ventilation, common during the rainy season, are compounding the problem by trapping allergens indoors.

Physicians say the condition is frequently mistaken for a common cold, since both cause a runny or blocked nose, sneezing and throat discomfort. The key to telling them apart lies in how long the symptoms last and how they behave over time, say doctors

Why humidity fuels the allergy season

Monsoon showers create near-perfect breeding conditions for allergens inside the home. Damp walls, carpets, mattresses, clothes and curtains can turn into hotspots for mould and dust mites, while the burst of vegetation that follows the rains adds pollen to the mix.

Dr Mahavir Modi, a Pune-based consultant pulmonologist, explains that the season's moisture is the common thread behind most of these triggers. "Monsoon rain brings a lot of moisture, which makes it easier for allergy-causing organisms to grow and worsens breathing problems for many people. This is a particular concern in a city like Pune," he says.

According to Dr Modi, mould and mildew can multiply rapidly on wet walls and other damp surfaces once humidity levels rise, while dust mites thrive in bedding, sofas and curtains under similar conditions. Pollen adds another layer to the problem. "Plants and grasses grow rapidly after the rains, which pushes up pollen levels," he says, adding, "And because people tend to keep their windows shut in wet weather, there's less fresh air circulating indoors so allergens end up trapped inside the home."

Cold or allergy? Watch the symptoms

Doctors caution that identifying whether symptoms stem from a viral infection or an allergic reaction is an important first step before reaching for over-the-counter medication.

Dr Dattatraya B. Patil, a consultant physician at a leading Pune hospital, says the timeline is often the clearest giveaway. A viral cold, he notes, typically resolves within seven to ten days and usually comes bundled with fever, body aches, a sore throat and thicker nasal discharge. "In allergic rhinitis, on the other hand, the nasal discharge is usually clear, and there is intense itching accompanied by repeated, continuous sneezing. Fever is generally absent, and symptoms can drag on for weeks," Dr Patil says.

There's also a difference in onset. While a cold tends to build up over a day or two before gradually easing, allergic symptoms can persist for as long as a person remains exposed to the trigger. Itching of the nose, eyes, mouth or throat is another telltale sign of an allergic reaction, Dr Patil adds, whereas viral infections are more commonly marked by a sore throat, fever and body ache.

The ripple effects of ignoring symptoms

While persistent allergic rhinitis may seem like a minor inconvenience, doctors warn that prolonged nasal blockage can quietly erode a person's quality of life. "When the nose stays blocked, people often start breathing through the mouth, which can lead to snoring and disturbed sleep. Over time, that shows up as daytime fatigue," Dr Modi says.

The knock-on effects don't stop there. He notes that persistent symptoms can chip away at concentration and performance at work or school, with headaches and constant nasal discomfort making it harder to stay focused through the day.

The asthma connection

Perhaps the most serious warning from doctors concerns the link between untreated rhinitis and the lower airways. Prolonged inflammation in the nose can interfere with normal sinus drainage, raising the risk of sinus infections, and the effects can extend further still.

"Untreated rhinitis can also worsen asthma symptoms. Because the nose and lungs are closely connected, inflammation in the nasal passage can affect the lower airways too, leading to coughing, wheezing and a flare-up of asthma symptoms," Dr Modi explains.

Dr Patil urges patients against repeatedly self-medicating without first identifying the underlying cause. "If symptoms continue for several weeks or keep coming back, it's best to consult a physician for a proper diagnosis and treatment, rather than assuming it's simply a recurring cold," he warns.

Simple steps to cut down exposure

Doctors say a handful of everyday precautions can go a long way in keeping allergic rhinitis in check during the monsoon. Keeping indoor humidity below 50 percent, using a dehumidifier or air-conditioning where possible combined with adequate ventilation, can help curb the growth of dust mites and mould.

"Regularly check damp corners, bathroom tiles and the areas behind furniture for mould, and clean them promptly. Keeping the home dry is especially important through the monsoon months," Dr Modi advises. Washing bedsheets and pillow covers in hot water at least once a week, and making sure bedding is completely dry before use, can further cut down dust-mite exposure.

Rinse, don't ignore

Doctors also recommend using saline nasal sprays or rinses to flush out allergens, mucus and other irritants from the nasal passages, particularly after returning home from outdoors. "Rinsing the nose with saline after coming indoors can help clear out pollen, mould spores and accumulated mucus. Anyone sensitive to allergens should also take extra precautions while visiting gardens or other spaces where pollen and spores tend to collect," Dr Modi says.

Above all, Dr Patil advises against ignoring prolonged sneezing, nasal blockage or breathing difficulties. "Early consultation can help distinguish an allergy from an infection and ensure the right treatment begins before symptoms lead to further complications," he says.

MIRROR HEALTH WATCH Pune Times Mirror

WHAT IS ALLERGIC RHINITIS?

It is an allergic reaction that causes inflammation inside the nose, leading to repeated sneezing, clear runny nose, itching and nasal blockage, often triggered by pollen, dust or mould.

STAY HEALTHY

Symptoms	Precautions
Snoring	Saline rinse
Fatigue	Wash hands
Headaches	Avoid allergens
Poor concentration	Wear masks
Sinus infections	Keep indoors dry
Worsened asthma	

LET YOUR HAIR BREATHE

Clutcher Alert: Your Favourite Hairstyle Accessory Could Be Putting Stress on Your Hair

Hair clutchers, claw clips and other easy-to-use hair accessories have become a daily favourite for many women. They are quick, comfortable and often considered a gentler alternative to tight rubber bands. But dermatologists warn that how you use a hair clutcher matters, especially when the hair is pulled tightly or the accessory is worn for long hours.

The concern is not necessarily the clutcher itself, but the constant tension, pulling and pressure it can put on the hair and scalp.

One condition linked to repeated tension on the hair is traction alopecia. According to the American Academy of Dermatology (AAD), hairstyles that continuously pull on the scalp can cause hair loss. If the tension continues for a long time, the damage can become permanent.

When does a clutcher become a problem?

A loosely placed clutcher that holds the hair without pulling is generally less concerning than a hairstyle that keeps the hair tightly stretched.

Problems can arise when people twist their hair tightly before securing it, use a very tight clip or repeatedly position the clip in the same area. Constant pressure and pulling can contribute to hair breakage and scalp discomfort. Pain or discomfort should not simply be ignored. Dermatologists point out that if a hairstyle hurts, it may be putting excessive tension on the scalp.

It is not just about hair fall

Repeated tension can first show up as tenderness, discomfort, broken strands or thinning around areas that experience the most pulling. Over time, continued tension may contribute to traction alopecia.

The AAD recommends avoiding hairstyles that continuously pull on the hair and suggests switching between hairstyles to reduce repeated stress. Does this mean you should stop using clutchers? Not necessarily.

The key is moderation and avoiding excessive tension. Choose a clip that is appropriate for your hair volume, avoid twisting the hair too tightly and give your scalp regular breaks.

Instead of keeping the same tightly pulled hairstyle throughout the day, let the hair down when possible. Also avoid repeatedly brushing or tugging at the hair, as excessive handling can contribute to breakage.

Watch out for these signs

If you regularly use hair clutchers or other accessories, pay attention to:

- Scalp pain or tenderness
- Hair breakage around the hairline
- Thinning near the temples
- Receding hairline
- Increased hair fall after removing the accessory
- Redness or irritation on the scalp

Time to see a dermatologist

If hair loss continues or becomes noticeable, it is better to consult a dermatologist rather than assuming the accessory is the only cause. Hair loss can have several causes, including genetics, hormonal changes, nutritional deficiencies and scalp conditions. Your hair accessory may look harmless, but repeated pulling is not. A hair clutcher does not automatically mean hair damage; the real issue is excessive tension and prolonged use. So, the next time you put your hair up, remember one simple rule: if your hairstyle hurts, it is too tight. Giving your hair and scalp regular breaks could help prevent unnecessary breakage and tension-related hair loss.



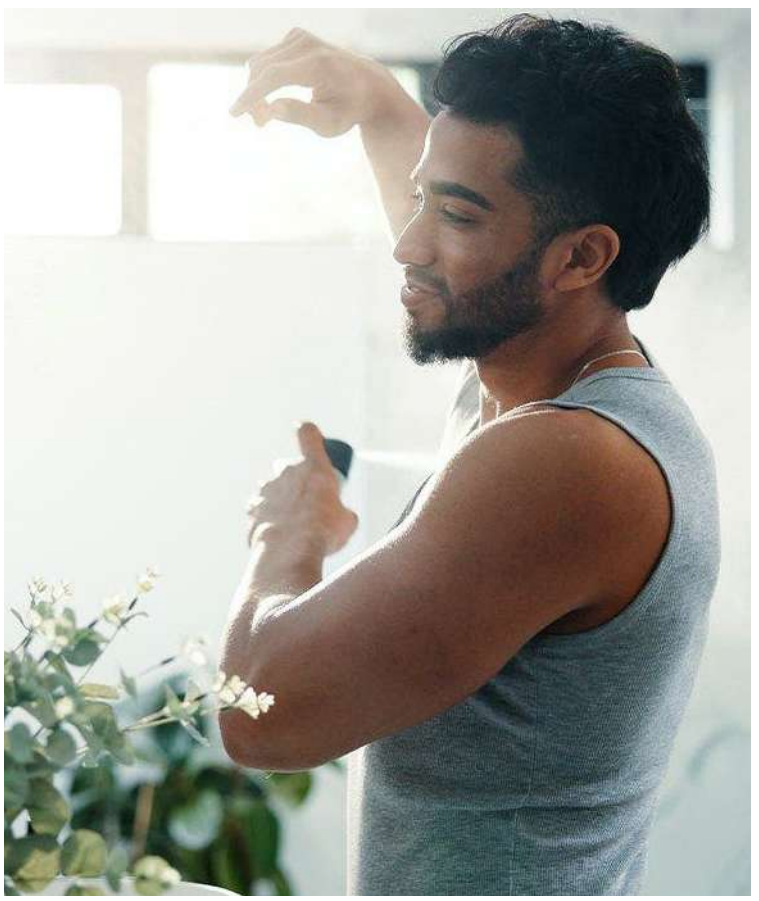
No Shower Before a Date!

Meet the 'Pheromone-Maxxing' Trend Taking Over Dating

You have picked the perfect outfit, checked your hair twice, sprayed your favourite perfume and are ready for a first date. But what if the latest dating trend tells you to do the exact opposite — skip the shower, ditch the deodorant and let your natural body smell do the flirting?

Sounds strange? Welcome to the world of pheromone-maxxing, a social media-driven trend that is encouraging some young men to believe that their natural body scent could make them more attractive to potential partners.

The trend is part of the internet's growing obsession with everything ending in "-maxxing" — essentially the idea of optimising one particular aspect of yourself. In this case, the focus is on supposedly maximising natural chemical signals that could influence attraction.



The idea behind the trend

Pheromones are chemical substances released by animals that can influence the behaviour or responses of other members of the same species. This has led some social media users to wonder whether humans might also have similar chemical signals that influence romantic attraction.

The theory is simple: if your natural scent could attract someone, why wash it away with soap, shampoo, deodorant or perfume before a date?

Some followers of the trend have reportedly taken it further by wearing unwashed clothes and deliberately avoiding deodorant to preserve their "natural musk".

But before you cancel your shower appointment, there is an important scientific catch.

Does your body odour really attract people? Science does not have a clear yes.

Researchers have not conclusively identified a human pheromone that can reliably make another person feel attracted. While studies have suggested that people can respond differently to natural body scents, the evidence remains mixed.

One frequently discussed experiment involved participants smelling T-shirts worn by other people. It suggested that natural body odour may carry information that people subconsciously respond to. However, subsequent research has not established a specific human chemical that works like an attraction switch.

So, having a natural scent is one thing. Believing that skipping your shower will automatically make your date fall for you is quite another.

Natural scent vs. smelling unpleasant

There is also a difference between allowing your natural scent to exist and deliberately avoiding basic hygiene.

Body odour can be influenced by several factors, including genetics, diet and the environment. But that does not mean an unwashed body is secretly producing a romantic superpower.

In fact, what one person considers an attractive natural scent may simply be unpleasant to another.

And that brings us to the biggest problem with the trend: attraction is personal.

The dating rule that still works

Dating trends may change every week, but some rules remain surprisingly simple.

Take a shower. Wear clean clothes. Use deodorant if you normally do. Wear a fragrance if you enjoy it — but don't overdo it.

Most importantly, don't treat social media trends as scientific fact.

The idea of pheromone-maxxing may make for an entertaining conversation starter, but there is currently no solid scientific evidence that skipping a shower will make your date more attracted to you.

After all, there is a difference between **"I like your natural scent" and "I can smell you from across the restaurant."

When it comes to first dates, perhaps the safest formula is still the oldest one:good hygiene, confidence and being yourself.

Jarange Patil ends hunger strike
— Maratha reservation activist Manoj Jarange Patil ended his hunger strike by drinking water offered by BJP MLC Prasad Lad, even as he maintained that he would remain firm on his demands and would call off the agitation only after their implementation begins.

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'3.5 CR LAKHPATI DIDIS CREATED'

Union Minister Shivraj Chouhan says target is 6 crore across the country

#MUMBAI
@ThePuneMirror

Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Thursday participated in a tree plantation drive alongside 'Lakhpati Didis' in Mumbai and held an interaction with women from Self-Help Groups (SHGs) ahed of his meeting with bankers.

"Today, I planted trees alongside 'Lakhpati Didis' in Mumbai. Our Prime Minister has pledged to create six crore Lakhpati Didis. I am happy to share that approximately 3.5 crore Lakhpati Didis have already been created, and we are now moving rapidly towards achieving the target of six crore," Chouhan said.

The Minister acknowledged that women often face difficulties in obtaining bank loans due to numerous formalities and delays in disbursement. "Before meeting with bankers, a meeting is scheduled for today in Mumbai; we decided to first consult the women themselves: those working in Self-Help Groups and starting various businesses to become Lakhpati Didis. We want to understand the difficulties and challenges they face," he said.

During the interaction, more than 100 Lakhpati Didis joined virtually from Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Uttarakhand.

A beneficiary running a CSP centre said she had received an individual loan four times, but other women had not, and some bank branches were refusing to accept more than one application. Responding, Chouhan said, "We will ask the bank why they are taking more than one application."


Shivraj Singh Chouhan with Lakhpati Didis.

A Self Help Group member from Maharashtra flagged that 21.49 per cent of the local population is tribal and they lack digital documents for banking, and that women were being denied loans due to poor CIBIL scores of their husbands. The Minister assured that he would take up the issue with bankers.

A woman entrepreneur from Bijnor said she started soap-making work in 2023 and her business grew rapidly, but her bank refused a loan for expansion and files remained stuck. Another beneficiary from Pune, working as a Bank Sakhi under Umed Abhiyan, said she got Rs 4 lakh from the bank and that some banks were asking for pollution certificates.

Chouhan said, "Our effort is that whatever obstacles are coming in the way of Didis starting their work, we are able to resolve those obstacles properly... We will soon create a helpline."

On the Lakhpati Didi initiative, he said, "The PM's aim under the Lakhpati Didi scheme is to make women strong entrepreneurs. We have to take it from three crore Lakhpati Didis to six crore Didis. Under that, today we have come to meet the Didis to understand their problems and to find a solution for them with the bankers."

The Union Minister told reporters, "They shared that while they have been able to start their own businesses and achieve 'Lakhpati' status thanks to bank loans, they are also facing various challenges. These issues include complex paperwork and formalities required for loans, the need for repeated bank visits, demands for guarantees or collateral, and instances where they receive a loan of only Rs 1.5 lakh despite needing Rs 5 lakh. We are currently heading into a meeting with bankers to address these matters... Our target is for SHGs to receive loans totalling Rs 10 lakh crore and for individual women to receive Rs 1 lakh crore over five years to support their work. Today's meeting with bankers is aimed at fulfilling this objective, following our discussions with the women."

A Lakhpati Didi is a Self-Help Group member who earns an annual household income of Rs 1,00,000 or more. This income is calculated for at least four agricultural seasons or business cycles, with an average monthly income exceeding Rs 10,000, so that it is sustainable. The initiative focuses on diversified livelihood activities for women. **ANI**

Sawant hits out at BJP

'I doubt their devotion towards god'

#MUMBAI
@ThePuneMirror

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Arvind Sawant recently questioned the appointment of Air Marshal Jitendra Mishra (Retd) as the first CEO of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

Reacting to the appointment, Sawant said, "It's okay, but that doesn't mean that whatever you do, the first crime is forgiven. You have committed theft, which is why we have to appoint an air marshal."

Sawant also raised questions over the Trust's devotion towards the god, saying, "I doubt and fear their devotion towards the god."

His comments came after the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Tirth Kshetra Trust on Wednesday appointed retired Air Marshal Jitendra Mishra as its Chief Executive Officer (CEO), besides appointing three new trustees.

The decisions were taken at a meeting of the Trust's trustees in Ayodhya, which also discussed the appointment of the CEO, filling vacant trustee posts, approval of the 2025-26 annual accounts, progress of the SIT probe into alleged financial irregularities and developments before the Supreme Court.

Mishra was appointed on the recommendation of the committee constituted for selection of the CEO. He has 39 years of experience in various branches of the Indian Air Force, extensive leadership experience and has been awarded the Uttam Yudh Seva Medal.



On the Bombay High Court directing the CBI to register an FIR in the Disha Salian death case, Sawant said the agency should proceed in accordance with the court's direction.

"It's okay if the court has advised them. I think in the past, the CBI made an inquiry, and after that, what they found, let them do it," he said. **ANI**

Nashik Kumbh

Hackathon deadline extended

Aimed at developing technology-driven solutions for the gathering

#NASHIK
@ThePuneMirror

The Nashik Trimbakeshwar Kumbh Mela Authority recently extended the deadline for its technology hackathon by 15 days to September 15, following requests from startups and young technology professionals seeking more time to submit solutions for key challenges of the upcoming Simhastha Kumbh Mela.

The hackathon, aimed at developing technology-driven solutions for the mega religious gathering, covers six key areas including sanitation, COVID/first response, 360-degree surveillance and security.

The original deadline was August 31. Around 50 solutions will be shortlisted for presentations, of which 18 will be selected. The top six will subsequently be presented before the Maharashtra Chief Minister at a proposed Tech Summit in Nashik.

Solutions found suitable will be considered for implementation during the Simhastha Kumbh Mela, Mela Authority Commissioner Shekhar Singh said.

Singh urged college students, startups and technology entrepreneurs to participate in the hackathon, calling it an opportunity to have innovative solutions deployed during the Kumbh Mela. Awards and other recognition are also proposed for selected participants.


File photo of Nashik Kumbh Mela

Earlier on Friday, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said the Kumbh Bhakti Sangam has begun while expressing confidence that all infrastructure and Kumbh-related works will be completed well before the first 'Parvani'.

He said the flag-hoisting ceremony for the Kumbh Mela in Nashik is scheduled for October 31, following which programmes will be conducted according to the dates already announced. Fadnavis added that the Bhakti Sangam aims to bring together devotional traditions from across the country and represents the spiritual essence of the Kumbh.

"The Kumbh Bhakti Sangam has begun today. Through this Bhakti Sangam, we are showcasing the devotional traditions from across the country. The real significance of the Kumbh is spiritual confluence. Therefore, through this event, we are trying to create a similar confluence of devotion," the Maharashtra CM said.

The Chief Minister acknowledged that people are currently facing inconvenience due to the large number of development works being undertaken simultaneously in Nashik and Trimbakeshwar. He assured residents that the ongoing projects would transform the face of Nashik and Trimbakeshwar once completed.

"All the Kumbh-related works are progressing rapidly. There are some difficulties, and we are working to resolve them. It is also true that people are facing inconvenience because of these works," Fadnavis said on Friday.

The Nashik Kumbh is held every 12 years, with people coming to take a holy dip in the Godavari River. **ANI**



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WILL WAR END OR CONTINUE?

Trump weighs declaring it over; Pentagon extends deployment of troops

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

Seven months into the Iran war, US President Donald Trump is privately weighing a declaration that the war is over, even while the Pentagon lengthens troop deployments in West Asia, pointing to the possibility that the tensions may continue into next year, according to a Wall Street Journal report.

The report appeared as a new wave of strikes took place between the US and Iran on Tuesday. The United States Central Command (CENTCOM) stated on Wednesday that it had conducted strikes against multiple sites inside Iran.

Tehran replied by hitting US-linked facilities across the Gulf.



Shia Muslims celebrate after the announcement of a two-week ceasefire by the US and Iran, in Srinagar in April ANI Photo

Iran strongly condemned the latest US strikes and accused Washington of violating its sovereignty and targeting non-military infrastructure and civilian sites in several Iranian provinces.

Iran's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said Iranian armed forces had responded with "crushing defensive strikes" against US military bases that it described as the origin, support and staging points for the American attacks.

Iranian officials stated that 18 people died and 142 others were wounded in the most recent US strikes.

According to the WSJ, Trump has spoken with senior aides about "whether to declare the Iran war over," a course he privately backs, especially with mid-term elections nearing and energy prices climbing because of the war.

The president takes the position that Iran will in time dismantle its nuclear programme under severe economic strain. The development followed the US start last week of Operation Economic Outcast, designed to hit Tehran's principal economic supports such as oil, shipping, aviation and digital assets.

Even as Trump presses for an end to the Iran war, US Secretary of War Pete Hegseth is quietly lengthening troop deployment in West Asia, "in a sign that the conflict could drag well into next year", the Wall Street Journal reported.

The decision is meant to leave the president with "options in the war", the outlet reported, citing sources familiar with the matter.

As the latest exchanges unfolded between the US and Iran, Washington guided 40 commercial ships through the key waterway on Tuesday, two US officials told CNN.

The figure for vessels protected in one operation stood as the highest so far in the ongoing war, they said.

US forces also hit nearly 60 Iranian military sites around the Strait of Hormuz. Targets covered air defence installations, radar systems, maritime infrastructure, mine-laying facilities and communications networks. **AGENCIES**

Rubio issues veiled warning

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio has said that he does not believe there are talks currently going on for a trade deal between India and Iran, while warning that countries helping Tehran amid the West Asia conflict to evade US sanctions could face sanctions themselves.

Rubio's remarks came after Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on the sidelines of the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, where the two leaders discussed bilateral ties, trade and the prevailing situation in West Asia.

Speaking to Brian Kilmeade on The Brian Kilmeade Show on Tuesday when asked about the meeting and whether India and Iran were setting up some form of trade deal, Rubio said, "Well, I don't think there's a trade deal between India and Iran."

The State Secretary further stated that countries develop their own foreign policies and noted that several countries maintain contact with the Iranian regime.

"Obviously, there are – countries all develop their own foreign policy, and many countries around the world talk to the Iranian regime," Rubio said.

The US Secretary of State, however, stressed the US position that countries should not assist Iran in circumventing sanctions. "I think what ultimately happens, though, is – and the President's been very clear – is no country should be helping Iran evade sanctions," Rubio. **AGENCIES**

Iran blacklists 11 vessels

More will be added for 'non-compliance': Hormuz control panel

#TEHRAN
@ThePuneMirror

Iran's Persian Gulf Strait Authority (PGSA) on Wednesday (local time) blacklisted a further 11 vessels transiting through the Strait of Hormuz over what it described as 'non-compliance' with Iranian protocols, taking the total number of vessels barred from the strategically important waterway to 56.

In a post on X, the PGSA said its Non-Compliant Vessels (NCV) list had been updated, while acknowledging information submitted by members of the public that contributed to the latest entries.

"The NCV list has been updated on the website. Certain entries on this list have been established through information voluntarily submitted by the public, and the PGSA wishes to formally acknowledge and thank those who have contributed to this effort," the authority said.

The PGSA, a regulatory body established by Iran to manage and monitor maritime operations through the strategic waterway, has warned that any vessel cooperating with a blacklisted ship could also be added to the list.

PGSA on its website stated vessels found violating Iranian protocols for the Strait of Hormuz could face restrictions on future passages, including fines, detention or confiscation.

The authority has also advised cargo owners shipping to and from the Persian Gulf to review the NCV list before chartering vessels to avoid potential issues.

"Any vessel cooperating with listed vessels (via STS, transhipment, etc.) will be added to the list," the PGSA said.



'RENAME IT TRUMP STRAIT?'

US President Donald Trump raised the prospect of renaming the Strait of Hormuz to the "Trump Strait", questioning the designation of the critical waterway in a social media release. In a statement published on his social media platform, Trump remarked, "Now that we have it under U.S.A. control, should we change the name Hormuz Strait to TRUMP STRAIT???" Asserting that the suggested title would be deemed "hotter" than previously, the post concluded with the signature "President DONALD J. TRUMP", alongside expressions of gratitude towards readers for their attention to his proposal.

The authority has stated that vessels seeking removal from the blacklist must submit a formal application with supporting justifications.

The latest action comes a week after Tehran blacklisted 45 tankers that it claimed had violated its rules for navigating the Strait of Hormuz.

On May 18, Iran's Supreme National Security Council formally launched the PGSA as a dedicated mechanism for governing maritime traffic through the Strait of Hormuz.

The council reported a statement announcing that the official X account of the Persian Gulf Strait Authority had become operational.

"In the Name of God. The official X account of the Persian Gulf Strait Authority (#PGSA) is now live. Follow us for real-time updates on the Hormuz Strait operations and latest developments," the authority said in the statement.

The establishment of the PGSA marked the formal introduction of a dedicated Iranian body to oversee maritime traffic and operations linked to the Strait of Hormuz, a strategically important waterway for global oil and energy shipments. **AGENCIES**

Saudi slams tanker attack

#RIYADH
@ThePuneMirror

Saudi Arabia on Wednesday claimed that Iran targeted an oil tanker, Sidr, as it transited through the Strait of Hormuz, resulting in fatalities among the vessel's crew.

In an official statement, Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs expressed stern condemnation of the action. Riyadh extended its condemnation to broader regional military action, citing Iranian attacks directed at Jordan, Bahrain, and Kuwait.

"The Ministry of Foreign Affairs expresses the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia's condemnation of the Islamic Republic of Iran's targeting of the Saudi tanker (Sidr) while it was transiting the Strait of Hormuz, and resulted in fatalities among the tanker's crew," the Ministry stated.

Saudi Arabia reaffirmed its full solidarity with these neighbouring nations and expressed unwavering support for any measures they take to safeguard their sovereignty and national security against external threats.

Highlighting the risks posed to global stability, the ministry underscored the urgent need to protect maritime trade routes and ensure the security of global energy supplies. The Kingdom emphasised adherence to the principles of international law, the UN Charter, state sovereignty, and good-neighbourly relations.

"The Kingdom stresses the need to halt escalation and respect the security and safety of international navigation," the statement read. **AGENCIES**

HEALTH TIP: The best foods for an upset stomach are bland, low-fat items that digest easily and help settle your digestive tract.



Bananas are easy to digest, and rich in potassium to replace lost electrolytes. White rice and toast or crackers are also recommended for people with an upset stomach.

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ASK THE SEXPERT



DR ROHAN JAHAGIRDAR
Psychiatrist & Sexpert

1 I am a 21-years-old female. I'm very used to wearing tampons. I think my hymen is broken. Does that mean I have lost my virginity with a tampon?
Dear Ma'am, tampons can cause the hymen to stretch or tear but that does not affect the virginity. Only having sex can affect your virginity status. Do see a doctor and get yourself checked for injury or local infection.

2 I am a 25-year-old female. I've been trying to get pregnant for the last 6 months but have failed. Is the process automatic wherein the sperm knows where to go into my fallopian tube or is it missing some direction?
Dear Ma'am, I think you're missing some information on how one gets pregnant! If you have been trying for 6 months do check with your doctor if you or your husband have some issues with fertility. The sperms will follow their natural biological journey and I don't think they will need GOOGLE MAPS for their direction! (pun intended) I hope you reach your destination!

3 I am a 22-year-old female.I have UTI and was prescribed some medicine for it. I'm scared to take it. Can I just have cranberry juice instead to cure my UTI?Please help.
Dear Ma'am, it can definitely help you with the summer heat! But you will need to take the medicine if you want to get better as having cranberry juice is not a treatment for UTI and it is unlikely to cure it.

4 I am a 19-year-old male. I masterbate everyday. I have been having hair loss recently. Will continuing my activity of masterbation cause more hair loss for me?
Dear Sir, unless you are pulling your own hair out that is unlikely to happen. (pun intended) as there is no scientific evidence that hair loss is caused due to masterbation. Do visit a doctor for your hair loss problem. Don't worry.

SEND YOUR QUERIES RELATED TO SEXUAL PROBLEMS TO
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YOU'RE THE FIRST GURU IN YOUR CHILD'S LIFE

ASK THE EXPERT PAEDIATRICIAN



Dr Sambhaji Mahadik, MBBS MD (Paediatrics), Consultant Paediatrician, Umarji Mother & Child Care Hospital

What are developmental milestones, and why are they important?
Developmental milestones are key skills and behaviors children typically achieve as they grow, such as sitting, walking, talking, and social interaction. These milestones help parents and professionals understand whether a child is developing on track. While each child develops at their own pace, milestones offer a general framework to identify strengths and potential areas needing support. They are important because early detection of delays can lead to timely interventions, which greatly improve long-term outcomes.

What role do parents play in supporting early physical development?
Parents are a child's first and most influential teachers. By providing a safe and stimulating environment, they encourage activities that build motor skills—such as tummy time for infants, playtime with soft toys, crawling, and outdoor activities as children grow. Parents who actively participate in play help strengthen their child's muscles, coordination, and confidence. Even simple interactions like guiding a baby's hand to reach for objects or encouraging a toddler to climb small steps can greatly support physical development.

How can parents promote language development in young children?
Language development thrives on daily interaction. Parents can support it through talking, reading, storytelling, and singing. Naming objects around the home, engaging in two-way conversations—even with infants—and responding to babbling encourage communication skills. Reading aloud daily helps children learn new words, sentence structures, and concepts. Parents who listen patiently and expand on a child's speech ("Yes, that's a dog! It's a big brown dog!") help enrich vocabulary and comprehension.

What is the role of parents in supporting cognitive development?
Parents nurture cognitive skills by offering opportunities for exploration and problem-solving. Age-appropriate toys, puzzles, sorting games, and creative play help stimulate thinking. Asking open-ended questions like "What do you think will happen next?" encourages curiosity and reasoning. Daily routines—such as cooking, grocery shopping, or even cleaning—can also become learning moments when parents involve children in counting, identifying shapes, or describing actions.

How can parents support emotional and social development?
Emotional security is fundamental to healthy development. When parents respond consistently and lovingly to their child's needs, the child learns trust and emotional regulation. Encouraging children to express feelings, modeling positive social behavior, and guiding them through conflicts helps build empathy and communication skills. Playdates, cooperative games, and family interactions further strengthen social competence.

What can parents do if they notice delays or have concerns?
If parents observe that their child is missing major milestones, it's important not to panic—but equally important not to ignore concerns. They should consult a pediatrician, early childhood specialist, or therapist for guidance. Early assessment and support can make a significant difference. Parents who stay informed, observant, and proactive provide the best foundation for their child's healthy development.

UMARJI Mother & Child Care

The views/suggestions/opinions/data in the article are the sole responsibility of the expert/organisation.
For queries, please write to **asktheexpert@punemirror.com**

LEND AN EAR, IT'S IMPORTANT...

Study finds a unique sound which alleviates motion sickness



A research group has discovered that using a device that stimulates the inner ear with a specific wavelength of sound reduces motion sickness.

Even a single minute of stimulation with a unique sound, called 'sound spice,' reduced the staggering and discomfort felt by people that were asked to read a document in a moving vehicle. Their findings suggest a simple and effective way to alleviate this common disorder.

A research group led by Takumi Kagawa and Masashi Kato at Nagoya University Graduate School of Medicine.

"Our study demonstrated that short-term stimulation using a unique sound called 'sound spice' alleviates symptoms of motion sickness, such as nausea and dizziness," Kagawa said.

"The effective sound level falls within the range of everyday environmental noise exposure, suggesting that the sound technology is both effective and safe," added Kagawa.

This discovery is an important expansion of recent findings about sound and its effect on the inner ear.

Increasing evidence has suggested that stimulating the part of the inner ear associated with balance using a unique sound can potentially improve balance. Using a mouse model and humans, the researchers identified a unique sound at 100 Hz as the optimal frequency.

"Vibrations at the unique sound stimulate the otolithic organs in the inner ear, which detect linear acceleration and gravity," Kato explained.

"This suggests that a unique sound stimulation can broadly activate the vestibular system, which is responsible for maintaining balance and spatial orientation," added Kato.

To test the effectiveness of the devices, they recruited voluntary participants who were exposed to the unique sound. Following the stimulation, motion sickness was induced by a swing, a driving simulator, or riding in a car.

The researchers used postural control, ECG readings, and Motion Sickness Assessment Questionnaire results to assess the stimulation's effectiveness.

The researchers found symptoms such as "lightheadedness" and "nausea," which are often seen with motion sickness, were alleviated.

"These results suggest that activation of sympathetic nerves, which are often dysregulated in motion sickness, was objectively improved by the unique sound exposure," Kato said.

"The health risk of short-term exposure to our unique sound is minimal," Kagawa said.

"Given that the stimulus level is well below workplace noise safety standards, this stimulation is expected to be safe when used properly."

Their results suggest a safe and effective way to improve motion sickness, potentially offering help to millions of sufferers. The researchers plan to further develop the technology with the aim of practical application for a variety of travel situations including air and sea travel.

IMMEDIATE RELIEF

- **Look ahead:** Stare at a fixed point in the distance or the horizon
- **Close your eyes:** Lean your seat back and rest with your eyes shut
- **Get fresh air:** Roll down the car window or turn on the air conditioner vents toward your face
- **Stop screens:** Put away phones, tablets, and books immediately
- **Sip or chew:** Try ginger ale, peppermint gum, or ginger candy

PREVENTION TIPS

- **Sit in front:** Move to the front passenger seat and face forward.
- **Eat light:** Have a small, bland snack like crackers before you travel instead of a heavy meal.
- **Take medication:** Use over-the-counter options like Dramamine or Bonine about an hour before your trip.
- **Stay still:** Rest your head against the headrest to limit movement

WHAT IS IT?

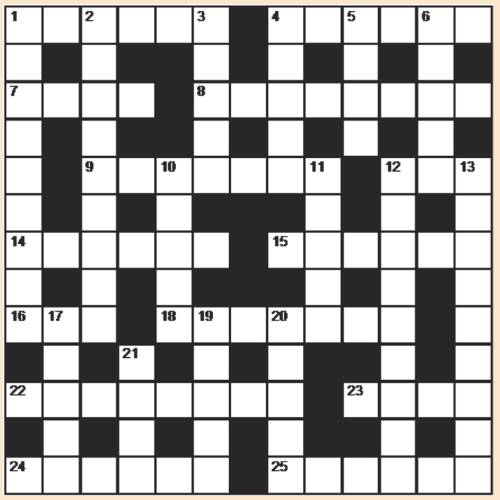
Motion sickness is a common condition that happens when you're in motion, like riding in a vehicle, while sitting still. It happens when your eyes, inner ear and body send conflicting messages to your brain. Symptoms include nausea, breaking out in cold sweat or headache. Fortunately, there are ways to prevent motion sickness or ease its symptoms.

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QUICK 6683



ACROSS
1 Fatal, doomed to die (6)
4 Natural well (6)
7 Long fish (4)
8 Retaliates against or punishes? (4,4)
9 Common, general or universal (7)
12 Second month in short (3)
14 Tempestuous (6)
15 Endorse (6)
16 Internet addresses (3)
18 Cavalryman, rough fierce fellow (7)
22 Major south Indian river (8)
23 Age-old town on the river Indrayani which was the birth place of Sant Tukaram (4)
24 Lebanon's capital (6)
25 Creamy dish (6)

DOWN
1 Ms. Sheshadri of Bollywood (9)
2 Devout or sacred (9)
3 Fall, decline or slip (5)
4 Digital pens (5)
5 Steals from (4)
6 Nook or recess (5)
10 Wanderer (5)
11 Belief system (5)
12 Struggles awkwardly (9)
13 Of ___ ____ : notorious or ill-famed? (3,6)
17 Set in position (5)
19 Strongly criticize (5)
20 Famous writer of fairy stories (5)
21 Duo (4)

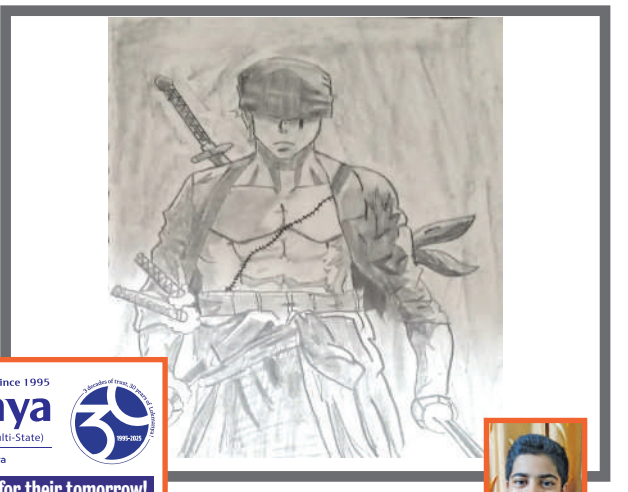
FOR ANSWER SCAN ↓

Please send copies of your children's artworks along with a photo of the artist in A4 size.
Do mention their age and the name of the school they attend. You can also mail us unpublished poems by children.





Vihaan Padole, 10 years,
The Orbis School, Keshav Nagar





Advait Jyoti, 11 years,
MIT VGS, Kothrud, Pune

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Priyadarshani School, Moshi





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WHAT YOUR STARS SAY TODAY

Aries
March 21 - April 20

You'll receive surprising support that will grow into real strength later. Connections are favored. If you can hold back your impatience, you'll come out ahead. Your rising optimism will give you an energy boost.

Taurus
April 21 - May 20

It's a great day to introduce changes that will improve your family life—especially in your romantic relationships. Your top priority is to strengthen your most important connections.

Gemini
May 21 - June 21

Opportunity is here for you to express yourself in harmony and to heal old wounds within the family or at work. If your mood doesn't take over, you'll come across as wonderfully idealistic. Keep a cool head and stay in control of your emotions.

Cancer
June 22 - July 23

You'll realize you made the right choice by staying patient. Success is now within reach. It's time to shake up your routine and bring back that easy, effortless feeling. A genuine break focused on your well-being would do you wonders.

Leo
July 24 – August 23

You'll feel like treating yourself—and honestly, it's exactly what you need to recharge today. Your great mood is contagious, and you're lifting the people around you.

Virgo
August 24 - September 23

Today, you'll have the gift of being in the right place at the right time—socially speaking. Positive encounters are strongly favored and can quickly turn into real friendship or a long-term collaboration.

Libra
September 24 - October 22

Big discoveries are on the horizon within your circle today. Stay understanding, and take a step back before you react... You're showing more pragmatism than usual. You also feel the urge to slow down. That way, you'll be even more effective.

Scorpio
October 23 - November 22

Your mood is better than ever, and it's helping you absorb new knowledge. Don't stay shut away—get out and live a little. You feel strong thanks to your positive mindset, but your body needs to unwind too.

Sagittarius
November 23 - December 22

Your practical instincts are sharper than ever today. You'll move mountains if you need to. And you'll feel even better when you take the time to balance and refresh your meals over the long run.

Capricorn
December 23 - January 20

Your drive, fueled by deep optimism, makes you bold. Today, nothing can stand in your way. Your moral compass is strong, and you're in great shape to embrace positive changes to the way you live.

Aquarius
January 21 - February 19

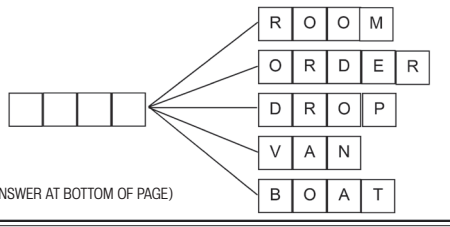
You may feel disappointed if you give in to the urge to help people who don't want it. You'll be calmer and more active at the same time. Everything is fine—just take a little time to refine your ideas in peace.

Pisces
February 20 - March 20

Your confidence in yourself will grow. Now is the perfect moment to set the record straight with someone in your circle. Your moral strength is returning. You'll also feel a surge of energizing, optimistic ideas. Still, your body is asking for more rest and care.

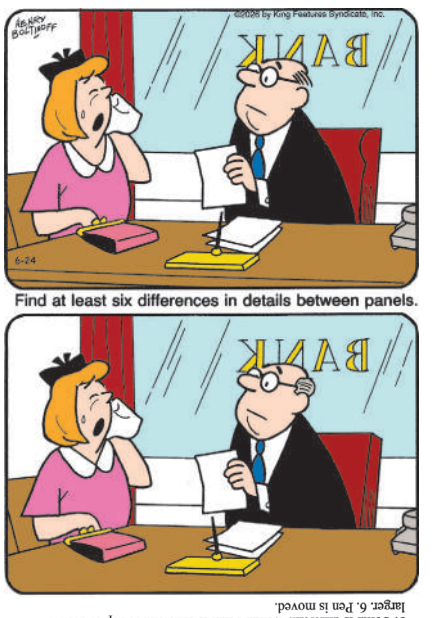
DOUBLE - BARRELLED

What word can be placed in front of the five words shown to form in each case another word ?



(ANSWER AT BOTTOM OF PAGE)

HOCUSFOCUS



Find at least six differences in details between panels.

Differences: 1. Back of chair is different. 2. Purse is moved. 3. Collar is different. 4. Man's hair is different. 5. Top of desk is larger. 6. Pen is moved.

ANSWER FOR DOUBLE-BARRELLED : Mail

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'MAIN TOH NAHI JAUNGI'

Mallika Sherawat Clears the Air on Bigg Boss 20 Entry

With the premiere of Bigg Boss 20 just around the corner, speculation over the celebrity lineup is growing by the day. One name that recently grabbed attention was Bollywood actor Mallika Sherawat. However, the actor has now put the rumours to rest, making it clear that she has no plans to enter Salman Khan's reality show.

Mallika was recently spotted in Mumbai with YouTuber and Bigg Boss OTT 2 winner Abhishek Malhan. During the interaction, paparazzi asked her directly whether she would be entering Bigg Boss 20. The actor gave a straightforward answer — "Nahi," later adding, "Main toh nahi jaungi," clearly ruling out her participation.

The clarification comes at a time when the upcoming season has been surrounded by several casting rumours. With Salman Khan returning as host, fans have been eagerly waiting to know which celebrities will step inside the controversial reality show. *Bigg Boss 20* is scheduled to premiere on September 6, adding to the buzz around the yet-to-be-revealed lineup.

Mallika's latest statement is also in line with her earlier comments about the show. In August, the actor had spoken about why the Bigg Boss format has never appealed to her. She explained that being confined inside a house while being constantly filmed is not the kind of reality television she enjoys. Instead, she has expressed greater interest in shows involving travel, adventure, food and conversations.

Interestingly, this is not the first time Mallika has been linked to Bigg Boss. Similar reports surfaced last year ahead of Bigg Boss 19, but she had then also denied plans to participate. Her latest response once again makes her position clear.

While Mallika will not be entering the Bigg Boss 20 house, reality television is not entirely off her list. She is currently appearing in Karan Johar-hosted The Traitors Season 2, where she has emerged as one of the contestants attracting attention. The finale of the show is scheduled for September 3.

Meanwhile, Bigg Boss 20 continues to generate curiosity with several celebrity names being linked to the season. However, many of these names remain part of speculation until officially confirmed by the makers.

For Mallika, the message is simple: despite the rumours and fan expectations, she is not walking into Salman Khan's Bigg Boss 20 house.

Orry Reveals His Secret



Orry, who is currently making headlines with his unexpected stint on Khatron Ke Khiladi 15, has revealed that he took up the challenging reality show without even informing his parents. Known for his glamorous social media presence and celebrity connections, Orry has surprised viewers by taking on several difficult stunts on the Rohit Shetty-hosted show.

Orry recently shared a video on Instagram featuring moments from his journey on the stunt-based reality show. Along with the video, he penned a note reflecting on his experience and explained that he deliberately chose to go through the journey without depending on anyone back home.

According to Orry, he travelled for the show "completely alone" and did not even tell his parents that he was participating. He said there were no regular calls, updates or discussions about the stunts he was performing. For him, the experience was about discovering what he could do when he had no audience, advice or familiar support system around him.

The social media personality also admitted that he initially considered surviving five episodes an achievement. As the competition progressed, he made it through seven episodes and then 10. Reaching the halfway point of the season left him surprised at his own progress.

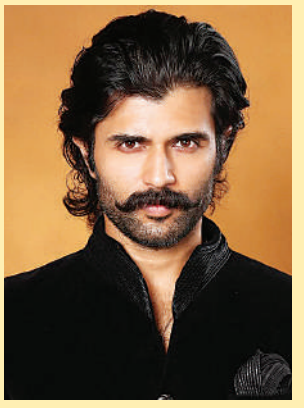
Orry's journey is particularly interesting because his public image is often associated with fashion, parties and Bollywood celebrity circles rather than physically demanding reality television. However, his appearance on Khatron Ke Khiladi 15 has shown viewers a different side of his personality.

In his note, Orry addressed the perception that he is delicate or unable to handle difficult situations. He said the show became a personal test for him, allowing him to prove to himself that he was not the "fragile Barbie doll" people sometimes make him out to be.

Orry did not claim to be a winner when reflecting on his performance. Instead, he acknowledged that he had lost several stunts but maintained that he approached each challenge with confidence.



Vijay Deverakonda Cheers for Rashmika's 'Mysaa'



Rashmika Mandanna is all set to enter a new action-packed phase with her upcoming film Mysaa, and husband Vijay Deverakonda is already cheering her on. The actor recently shared his first reaction to the film's newly unveiled look and release announcement, praising Rashmika's performance and expressing confidence that she will win over her fans once again.

The makers of Mysaa recently released a striking poster featuring Rashmika in a fierce and intense avatar. Unlike the glamorous roles audiences have often seen her play, the actor appears to be stepping into a much more physically demanding and action-oriented character. The poster has already created curiosity among fans who are eager to see her in this new avatar.

Vijay took to social media to share the poster and encouraged Rashmika ahead of the film's release. Calling her "Violent Pilla", he wished her well and said that she would make her fans proud with the project. His affectionate message quickly caught the attention of fans, who were delighted to see the actor openly supporting his wife's latest work.

Mysaa is expected to showcase Rashmika in one of the more challenging roles of her career. The film is being positioned as an action thriller, with its story set against a distinctive tribal backdrop. The makers have also teased high-intensity sequences, including an underwater action sequence, suggesting that the film will be considerably different from Rashmika's previous outings.

The road to Mysaa has not been completely smooth for the actor. Rashmika recently suffered an injury while working on the film. She later revealed that a tendon in her hip area had snapped, forcing her to take several weeks away from work to recover. Despite the setback, she has continued to remain connected with her upcoming projects and is gradually returning to her professional commitments.

Vijay's support comes at an interesting point in Rashmika's career. The actor has previously spoken about how much she values his honest opinions and considers him one of her biggest supporters. Their professional equation has also been closely followed by fans, especially as the two are set to reunite on screen in Ranabaali.

For Rashmika, Mysaa could mark another opportunity to experiment with a different side of her acting abilities. After making a strong impact in films across Telugu, Kannada and Hindi cinema, the actor is now taking on a character that appears to demand more intensity, physicality and emotional strength.

The film is scheduled to arrive worldwide on November 27, 2026.